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VENTURE



VC Victor Lazarte is
leaving Benchmark to
launch his own firm

EXIT

After two years as a venture capitalist for top-shelf firm Benchmark, Victor Lazarte is leaving that company to start his own investing gig, he announced on [X on Thursday](#).

Lazarte became known in tech for co-founding mobile gaming company Wildlife Studios, which was last valued at an estimated \$3 billion in 2020. Wildlife raised money from a multitude of VCs, including Benchmark.

During his two years at Benchmark, Lazarte invested in recruiting and data labeling startup [Mercor](#), AI video intelligence platform HeyGen, and AI infrastructure company [Decart AI](#).

Lazarte is leaving Benchmark to “build a new investment practice,” he wrote in the post. He had recently informed his portfolio companies about his plans to leave Benchmark, according to a source.

Lazarte is the second investor to step down from Benchmark’s partnership this year. Sarah Tavel announced in April that she is transitioning to a [venture partner](#).

After Lazarte’s departure, remaining partners at the storied firm include Peter Fenton, Eric Vishria, and Chetan Puttagunta.

Unlike most VC firms, where senior partners typically receive a greater share of management fees and profits, Benchmark operates as an [equal](#)

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partnership, with all general partners dividing fees and returns equally. Benchmark and Lazarte did not immediately respond to our request for additional comment.



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Marina Temkin

Reporter, Venture |

Marina Temkin is a venture capital and startups reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining TechCrunch, she wrote abou...

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Benchmark fills out its, yes, bench, with Miles Grimshaw

Connie Loizos — 10:30 AM PST · December 11, 2020

Benchmark, the storied venture firm, has brought aboard a fifth general partner: 29-year-old Miles Grimshaw, a Yale graduate who joins the outfit from Thrive Capital, where he similarly joined a team of four other partners back in 2013, helping them raise the firm's [fourth and fifth funds](#) (per Forbes).

From his post as a general partner with New York-based Thrive, Grimshaw had sourced deals in some of today's buzziest startups and served on their boards, including Lattice, Mapbox, Benchling and Airtable, getting to know fellow investors at Benchmark in the process.

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He represented Thrive on the board of [Benchling](#) — whose software helps lab scientists manage their biotech research — with Eric Vishria, a former entrepreneur and operator who joined Benchmark as a general partner in [2014](#).

Grimshaw also represented Thrive on the board of the cloud collaboration software company [Airtable](#) with Peter Fenton, who became the longest-serving general partner at Benchmark this year, as famed VC Bill Gurley began [transitioning out](#) of an active role at the firm. (Fenton was [poached from Accel](#) back in 2006.)

[Bill Gurley is stepping away from an active role at Benchmark, 21 years after joining the firm](#)

And Grimshaw has been serving on a board with

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Supergreat is among Benchmark's newest bets. It was announced earlier this month that Benchmark led the startup's \$6.5 million Series A round.

Before hiring Grimshaw, Benchmark's newest general partner was Chetan Puttagunta, who [joined the firm in 2018](#) from New Enterprise Associates, where he spent more than seven years.

Benchmark has done better than some firms when it comes to succession, even while many of its general partners remain involved in startups long after they move on from the firm's day-to-day operations.

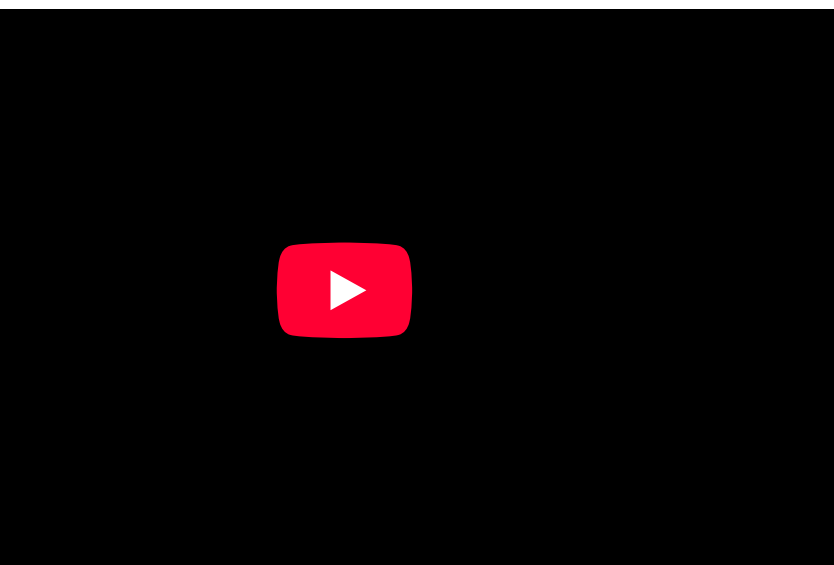
Firm cofounder Bruce Dunlevie, for example, joined the board of WeWork back in 2012. He's now part of a [lawsuit](#) alleging fellow WeWork investor SoftBank of breach of contract and breach of fiduciary duty, after SoftBank abandoned a tender offer to buy out earlier shareholders following WeWork's pulled IPO last year.

Reportedly, Matt Cohler — a former Facebook exec who left an active role as a general partner with Benchmark [in 2018](#) after a decade with the firm — separately helped Benchmark [secure its spot](#) in summer as the lead Series A investor in Popshop Live, a live-streaming e-commerce platform. According to The Information, Cohler agreed to join the startup's board of directors to help seal the deal.

In addition to Cohler and Gurley, who've stepped back in recent years, Mitch Lasky, who joined the firm in 2007, also stepped away from its core team in 2018.

Benchmark made it known this summer that it was looking to bring aboard a fifth partner, one who likely completes the firm’s roster for now. As Fenton told us in September when he [sat down](#) with us at our TechCrunch Disrupt event, Benchmark “can’t scale. When we’ve gotten above six partners, the firm doesn’t work so well.”

Fenton talked at some length about how Benchmark views the composition of its team. We also talked about that WeWork deal. If you’re curious to learn more, you can watch that interview below.



Topics: [Benchmark](#) [Miles Grimshaw](#) [personnel moves](#)

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Connie Loizos

Editor in Chief & General Manager | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [in](#) [Home](#)

Loizos has been reporting on Silicon Valley since the late '90s, when she joined the original Red Herring magazine....

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First look at the Startup Battlefield judges at TechCrunch Disrupt 2024

Richard Smith,

Isabelle Johannessen

11:40 AM PDT · August 21, 2024



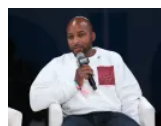
The [Startup Battlefield](#) is the crown jewel of Disrupt, and we can't wait to see which of the thousands of applicants will be selected to pitch to panels of top-tier VCs at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2024](#), taking place on October 28–30 in San Francisco. It's always epic, and every contender is on the road to making a huge impact on the world.

We're thrilled to reveal our first group of investors who will assess the startups and follow up each

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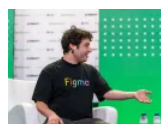


How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events

- 13 hours ago

STARTUPS



Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo

- 16 hours ago

pitch with an intense, revealing Q&A. Be on the lookout for more names being announced soon!

The judges' feedback provides insight into the criteria they use to determine whether a company is viable or not. Watch and learn what investors look for, what motivates them and what pushes them to schedule a meeting.

Here are the first five VCs ready to help decide the champion of Startup Battlefield 2024.

Erin Harkless Moore, Managing Director, Pivotal Ventures

Erin is the Managing Director of Investment for [Pivotal Ventures](#), a Melinda French Gates company created to accelerate social progress. Erin leads the organization's fund and direct investment decisions, overseeing a diverse portfolio of investments that drive breakthrough innovations. With nearly 20 years of investment experience in building and managing customized portfolios for endowed institutions and family offices, Erin's commitment to discovering and cultivating relationships with leaders, entrepreneurs, investors, and founders has been a driving force behind her success.

Eylul Kayin, Partner, Gradient Ventures

Eylul is a partner at [Gradient Ventures](#). Prior to Gradient, Eylul was an investor with NEA and SoftBank, where she supported a number of category-defining companies, including Brex, Cato, Chime, Claroty, Digits, Eargo (NASDAQ: EAR), Ethos, Flexport, Material Bank, Neotract (acquired by Teleflex) and Revella Aesthetics (incubation).

Victor Lazarte, General Partner, Benchmark

STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis

- 16 hours ago

Victor is a general partner at [Benchmark](#), where he focuses on a variety of investment areas, including AI, gaming and fintech. Victor co-founded Wildlife Studios in 2010 and built it into one of the largest mobile gaming companies in the world, engaging billions of players around the globe. From 2010 to 2023, Victor served as the co-founder and CEO of the company, before transitioning to chairman of the board in June of 2023. Victor has also served as a board member of Brex since 2018.



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Ana Leyva, GTM, Pear VC

Ana leads the go-to-market team at [Pear VC](#). With a rich background in enterprise sales from companies like Vanta, ServiceTitan, and Box, she is passionate about helping early-stage founders build high-performing sales motions. An entrepreneur herself, she founded and served as the CEO of the edtech startup Lelu.

Corinne Riley, Partner, Greylock

Corinne partners with early-stage founders who are creating data and AI products at the infrastructure and application layers. She works with companies like Adept, Baseten, Braintrust, Common Room, Opal, and WarpStream.

Corinne built [Greylock](#)'s Edge program, which is a company-building program that seeks out promising founders and ideas at the earliest stages and works with them to get those ideas off the ground. She also launched Greylock's Scout program, which invites top angel investors to form a special relationship with Greylock.

Don't miss it!

The winner of Startup Battlefield, who will walk away with a \$100,000 equity-free prize, will be announced at [Disrupt 2024](#). This is your chance to see the future of tech unfold — don't miss it! Grab your tickets by August 23 to save up to \$600. [Secure your ticket savings now.](#)

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Richard Smith

Director of Event Programming

Richard is the director of event programming for TechCrunch.

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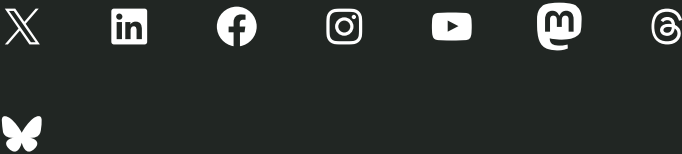
Isabelle Johannessen

Startup Battlefield Program Manager

Isabelle leads Startup Battlefield, TechCrunch’s iconic launchpad and competition for the world’s most promisin...

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